

LEGAL MATTERS

Criminal Prosecution OS Blueprint

Version v1.0 | South African criminal prosecution, private prosecution, docket intelligence, evidence readiness, live testimony capture, and courtroom assistive AI

North-star product promise

Legal Matters Criminal Prosecution OS helps prosecution teams, private prosecution practitioners, complainant-side attorneys, investigators, and litigation support teams manage criminal matters with evidence discipline, witness control, courtroom readiness, source-cited AI, and live testimony intelligence while preserving fairness, auditability, and human legal oversight.

Operating architecture at a glance

Layer	Purpose
Criminal Matter OS	Case theory, charges, accused, complainant, court dates, docket status, prosecutor ownership.
Evidence and Exhibit Ledger	Exhibits, digital files, forensic records, chain of custody, admissibility risk, linked charge elements.
Witness Intelligence Hub	Statements, attendance, contradictions, vulnerability, intimidation risk, preparation status.
Live Courtroom Capture	Permission-gated recording, live notes, transcript, snippets, testimony cross-reference, follow-up prompts.
Prosecution Readiness Engine	Charge proof matrix, witness readiness, evidence completeness, procedural readiness, court-day readiness.
AI Governance Layer	Sources, confidence, missing information, review status, audit logs, and prosecutor approval controls.

Item	Value
Document version	v1.0
Prepared for	Legal Matters product development
Market focus	South African legal sector: criminal prosecution, private prosecution, prosecution support, forensic litigation support
Primary users	Prosecutors, attorneys, candidate attorneys, paralegals, investigators, evidence analysts, practice managers, external counsel
Date	26 May 2026
Important note	This is a product blueprint, not legal advice. All legal workflow assumptions must be reviewed by qualified South African criminal law practitioners before production use.

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The delivered DOCX uses Word heading styles throughout. In Microsoft Word or LibreOffice Writer, the navigation pane can be used as a live table of contents. Page numbers are included in the footer.

1. Executive Product Vision

Legal Matters Criminal Prosecution OS is a specialised vertical module built on top of the wider Legal Matters platform. It is designed to transform criminal prosecution preparation from scattered dockets, ad hoc notes, and disconnected documents into a controlled prosecution command centre.

The product must help the prosecution team answer one operational question at all times: what must be proved, what evidence proves it, which witness proves it, what can go wrong, and what must be done next?

Product thesis

Criminal prosecution is not won by document storage alone. It is won through disciplined proof mapping, witness readiness, evidentiary control, live courtroom awareness, fair-trial safeguards, and rapid response to contradictions or missing facts.

Strategic objective	Product interpretation
Control the case theory	Maintain a clear prosecution theory, linked to charges, witnesses, exhibits, risks, and courtroom events.
Improve evidence readiness	Track every exhibit, statement, digital file, forensic report, and chain-of-custody record.
Strengthen witness management	Monitor witness availability, statement quality, intimidation risk, contradictions, interpreter needs, and preparation status.
Assist live proceedings	Capture court sessions, create testimony snippets, compare live testimony with matter data, and suggest fair follow-up steps.
Protect fairness and auditability	Ensure AI remains assistive, source-linked, permission-gated, and subject to prosecutor review.
Reduce preventable postponements	Track missing evidence, absent witnesses, incomplete reports, defence issues, court logistics, and delay causes.

1.1 Product identity

Dimension	Decision
Product category	AI-assisted criminal prosecution operating system and prosecution-readiness platform.
Primary buyer	Private prosecution teams, law firms, prosecution-support units, forensic investigation firms, public-interest litigation teams, and later institutional prosecution bodies.
Primary user	Prosecutor, lead attorney, evidence analyst, investigator, paralegal, witness coordinator, practice manager, external counsel.
Primary value	More disciplined prosecution preparation, stronger witness control, fewer missed gaps, faster docket review, and better courtroom response.
Primary differentiator	Live courtroom testimony intelligence connected to charge elements, witness statements, docket data, evidence records, and prosecutor next-step suggestions.
MVP promise	A prosecution team can manage a criminal matter, charges, witnesses, evidence, court sessions, live notes, snippets, readiness scoring, and AI-assisted next steps in one platform.

1.2 Success metrics

Metric	Target outcome	Why it matters
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Docket review time	Reduce first-pass review time by 40-60%	Proves value of AI docket summaries and evidence extraction.
Witness readiness	100% of key witnesses have status, statement, attendance, and risk tracking	Prevents avoidable witness failures.
Charge proof visibility	Every charge has a proof matrix before trial	Shows whether each legal element is supported.
Missing evidence closure	Reduce unresolved evidence gaps before court dates	Improves court readiness.
Court-day surprises	Material new issues captured and assigned on the same day	Improves response to live case developments.
Delay attribution	Every postponement has a reason, owner, and next action	Improves operational accountability.

2. Strategic Positioning and Scope

This vertical should be positioned as a criminal prosecution command centre, not as a generic criminal law module. The value is in prosecution-specific intelligence: docket control, witness risk, charge readiness, evidence admissibility, live testimony awareness, and court-day operational discipline.

Positioning option	Assessment
Criminal law module	Too broad and generic. It does not communicate evidence, witness, and prosecution-readiness intelligence.
Prosecution case-management module	Useful, but still sounds administrative.
Criminal Prosecution OS	Best framing. It signals a full operating layer for prosecution workflows, courtroom events, AI support, and readiness.
Courtroom AI Assistant	Too narrow. Live court assistance is a flagship feature, but not the whole product.

2.1 Target users

User group	Use case	Initial priority
Private prosecution teams	Manage prosecution preparation, witness statements, evidence packs, and court-readiness.	High
Complainant-side attorneys	Assist victims or complainants where prosecution support, review, or private prosecution is required.	High
Criminal litigation departments	Manage criminal matters, court dates, evidence, witnesses, and trial strategy.	High
Forensic investigation teams	Convert investigation material into prosecution-ready evidence maps and summaries.	Medium
Anti-corruption or public-interest teams	Manage high-profile evidence-heavy matters with transparency and audit trails.	Medium
Public prosecution institutions	Long-term institutional adoption after governance, security, and procurement readiness.	Future

2.2 Product boundary

In scope	Out of scope for MVP
Criminal matter workspace, accused and complainant records, charges, court dates, witnesses, evidence, live notes, snippets, readiness scoring.	Certified official court transcription, automatic public court filing, full national docket integration, direct SAPS/NPA production integration.
Permission-gated audio-recording architecture and manual-first court session capture.	Uncontrolled recording, covert recording, automatic publication, or AI acting as prosecutor.
AI summaries, contradiction flags, source-linked suggestions, missing evidence prompts.	Final legal opinions, guilt findings, witness truthfulness findings, or predictions of conviction.

3. South African Criminal Proceedings Context

The product must be South African-first. It must respect the constitutional right to a fair trial, the procedural realities of criminal matters, witness protection considerations, court permission requirements for recordings, and POPIA risks when processing audio, transcripts, biometric voice data, and sensitive personal information.

Context	Product implication
Fair-trial rights	The platform must not prejudice the accused, hide disclosure risks, make guilt findings, or create uncontrolled AI outputs.
Criminal Procedure Act framework	Workflows must support charges, bail, witnesses, trial procedure, evidence handling, postponements, and court events.
Witness protection	Witness intimidation and vulnerability must be tracked and escalated, not treated as normal task management.
Court recording permission	Recording must be disabled by default and only activated after a permission gate is completed.
POPIA	Audio, transcript, personal identifiers, biometric voice recognition, and sensitive witness data require strict purpose, access, retention, and audit controls.
High-profile risk	Media pressure, leaks, witness intimidation, and political narratives must be handled through integrity protocols and role controls.

Design rule

The platform must support the prosecutor's duty to act lawfully, fairly, independently, and evidence-first. It must never become an AI system that decides guilt, manipulates witnesses, or bypasses court permission and procedural safeguards.

4. Product Principles and Non-Negotiables

Principle	Meaning in product decisions
Matter-first	Every charge, witness, exhibit, transcript, note, AI output, task, and court date links to a criminal matter.
Proof-first	Every charge must be mapped to evidence and witnesses. Unsupported charge elements must be visible.
Witness-aware	Witness status, safety, consistency, language, attendance, and readiness are first-class data objects.
Human-in-control AI	AI suggests and flags; prosecutors review, decide, approve, or reject.

Source-cited outputs	AI outputs must cite matter data, transcript timestamps, document names, statement versions, evidence IDs, or court-session snippets.
Recording permission by design	Recording cannot start until the user confirms court permission or lawful internal-session status.
Audit by default	Every critical action is logged, including recording start/stop, transcript edits, snippet approvals, and AI suggestions.
Fairness preservation	The system must protect fair-trial integrity, disclosure discipline, and defence issue tracking.

4.1 Red lines

- No covert or default courtroom recording.
- No AI finding that an accused is guilty.
- No AI finding that a witness is lying.
- No external communication, victim update, investigator instruction, or court document sent without human approval.
- No use of excluded, sealed, privileged, or restricted documents in AI outputs.
- No deletion of audit records for recording, evidence, transcript, or AI actions.
- No broad access to sensitive criminal matters without explicit role and matter permissions.
- No final witness statement generated directly from AI without legal practitioner review and witness confirmation where required.

5. Criminal Prosecution Operating Model

The operating model should mirror how a disciplined prosecutor thinks: theory, charges, evidence, witnesses, admissibility, defence attacks, live court events, court record, and next actions.

Criminal Matter

- > Case Theory
- > Charges
- > Charge Elements
- > Evidence Items
- > Witnesses
- > Court Sessions
- > Live Testimony Snippets
- > Contradictions / Missing Proof / Next Actions
- > Prosecution Readiness Score

Stage	Operational objective	Legal Matters output
Intake	Capture case, complainant, accused, court, docket, and prosecution route.	Criminal matter profile and docket metadata.
Docket review	Understand facts, statements, evidence, and gaps.	Docket summary, chronology, witness list, evidence list, missing items.
Charge framing	Map charges to required proof areas.	Charge element proof matrix.
Witness preparation	Confirm attendance, statement status, risk, and consistency.	Witness readiness dashboard and prep log.
Evidence readiness	Confirm exhibits, chain of custody, admissibility risk, and court pack.	Evidence ledger and exhibit index.
Court appearance	Capture live testimony, court rulings, objections, exhibits, and next steps.	Court session workspace, live snippets, suggestion panel.
Post-court control	Update tasks, risks, delays, witness issues, and defence versions.	Court-day brief, delay log, defence tracker, readiness update.

6. High-Profile Prosecutor Playbook

A high-profile case must be run as a controlled prosecution operation. Public attention, media pressure, political narratives, witness fear, and procedural scrutiny make discipline essential.

6.1 Prosecutor questions every day

- What must I prove today?
- Which witness or evidence proves it?
- Is that evidence admissible and reliable?
- Which witness is vulnerable, missing, intimidated, hostile, or inconsistent?
- What new defence version or theory has emerged?
- What did the court hear today that differs from the docket?
- What could cause an appeal, review, postponement, or exclusion of evidence?
- What must be fixed before the next appearance?
- Am I still acting fairly, lawfully, independently, and evidence-first?

6.2 Prosecutor case-control checklist

Area	Question	Platform response
Charge sheet	Are charges properly framed and supported?	Charge readiness view and missing element alerts.
Witnesses	Are witnesses available, prepared, safe, and consistent?	Witness readiness and risk dashboard.
Evidence	Is evidence complete, indexed, admissible, and linked to charges?	Evidence ledger, chain-of-custody view, exhibit pack.
Defence	What will the defence attack?	Defence version tracker and rebuttal tasks.
Court logistics	Are interpreter, equipment, exhibits, video playback, and experts ready?	Court-day brief and logistics checklist.
Record	Is every event, ruling, objection, and delay captured?	Court session record and delay attribution log.

7. Unforeseen Case Risks and Mitigation Model

The product must assume that high-profile criminal matters will change under pressure. The design must make surprises visible and actionable before they become trial failures.

Unforeseen element	Impact	How Legal Matters helps overcome it
Witness changes evidence in court	Contradiction, credibility challenge, weakened case theory.	Live testimony comparison, contradiction radar, follow-up question suggestions, witness risk update.
Witness intimidation or disappearance	Key evidence may be lost or weakened.	Witness safety status, last-contact tracking, escalation workflow, protection referral marker.
New defence version	Timeline, identity, intent, causation, or lawfulness may be challenged.	Defence version tracker, rebuttal evidence tasks, investigator requests.
Missing forensic report	Charge element may remain unsupported.	Missing evidence command centre and court-date risk escalation.
Chain-of-custody attack	Evidence may be disputed or excluded.	Evidence ledger, handover history, digital hash, authenticity status.

Media leak	Fair-trial and integrity concerns.	Media risk register, access log review, restricted matter controls.
Political pressure	Perception of bias or overcharging.	Evidence-only case theory, approval workflows, integrity protocol.
Court technology failure	Video, recording, or exhibit playback failure.	Court logistics checklist, offline notes, upload-after-session support.
Interpreter unavailable	Postponement or fairness issue.	Interpreter requirement flag and court-day readiness alert.
Accused changes representation	Delay and preparation issues.	Delay attribution log and revised court readiness tasks.

8. Core Platform Modules

Module	Purpose	MVP scope
Criminal Matter OS	Central workspace for the case.	Matter profile, parties, charges, court dates, tasks, risk, status.
Case Theory Workspace	Define what the state alleges and how it will be proved.	Theory statement, issues, proof themes, weak points, defence assumptions.
Charge Readiness Engine	Map every charge to proof areas.	Charge elements, linked evidence, linked witnesses, missing proof, readiness score.
Witness Intelligence Hub	Manage witnesses as core prosecution assets.	Witness profiles, statements, attendance, preparation, safety, contradiction risk.
Evidence and Exhibit Ledger	Control evidence, exhibits, and chain of custody.	Evidence IDs, source, storage, handover, linked charges/witnesses, risk.
Live Courtroom Capture	Capture and analyse courtroom developments.	Permission gate, live notes, snippets, transcript placeholder, follow-up suggestions.
Docket Intelligence AI	Summarise and structure docket material.	Docket summary, chronology, missing evidence, contradiction flags.
Court Preparation Workspace	Prepare for each court appearance.	Court-day brief, witness list, exhibit list, logistics, next actions.
Defence Version Tracker	Track and respond to defence theories.	Version raised, risk, rebuttal evidence, investigator tasks.
Delay Attribution Log	Track postponement causes and ownership.	Date, reason, party, impact, next action.

9. Criminal Matter OS

The criminal matter workspace is the operational home of the case. It should be deliberately different from a civil matter because it must include accused persons, charges, bail status, docket metadata, witness risk, evidence admissibility, court events, and prosecution readiness.

Field group	Fields
Case identity	Matter number, docket/CAS number, court case number, court, case title, prosecution route, case status.
Parties	Accused persons, complainant/victim, witnesses, investigating officer, prosecutor, defence attorney if known.
Charges	Charge category, statutory/common-law basis, particulars, linked elements, alternative charges.

Court	Court type, court room, presiding officer, next date, appearance type, outcome history.
Bail	Custody status, bail application dates, bail conditions, intimidation risk, bail breach alerts.
Evidence	Evidence list, exhibit IDs, chain-of-custody state, digital evidence hashes, admissibility risk.
Witnesses	Statement status, attendance, preparation, interpreter need, safety risk, contradiction risk.
AI and audit	Docket summaries, charge maps, live testimony snippets, source references, review status, audit history.

10. Charge Element Proof Matrix

The charge element proof matrix is the heart of the prosecution-readiness model. Every charge must be broken into proof requirements. Each requirement must be linked to evidence and witnesses.

Charge	Element / proof area	Evidence	Witness	Risk / action
Fraud	Misrepresentation	Email thread EXH-003; complainant statement	Complainant	Clarify exact representation made.
Fraud	Intent	Pattern of emails; prior conduct evidence	Investigator; analyst	Intent inference requires stronger chronology.
Fraud	Prejudice or potential prejudice	Bank record EXH-006; invoice file	Accountant	Confirm amount and loss calculation.
Assault	Identity	Witness statement; CCTV	Eyewitness; CCTV analyst	Lighting and visibility must be clarified.
Assault	Unlawful act	Medical report; photos	Complainant; doctor	Medical report not yet uploaded.
Theft	Property ownership	Asset register; invoice	Owner representative	Original invoice missing.

10.1 Matrix behaviours

- Show unsupported elements in red and partially supported elements in amber.
- Allow users to link evidence items, witness statements, transcript snippets, and court admissions to a charge element.
- Require a human review status before marking an element as ready.
- Keep version history when charge particulars or element mappings change.
- Generate missing-proof tasks automatically when a court date is approaching.

11. Witness Intelligence Hub

Witness testimony is often the most important source of proof in criminal proceedings, and it changes under courtroom pressure. Legal Matters must treat witnesses as dynamic, high-risk prosecution assets.

Capability	Description
Witness profile	Name, role, contact, language, interpreter requirement, relationship to parties, vulnerability, safety risk.
Statement management	Statement date, signed status, version, author, linked exhibits, inconsistencies, correction history.
Attendance control	Availability, subpoena status, service status, transport needs, court-day confirmation.

Preparation log	Ethical preparation record: process explained, statement reviewed, risks noted, no coaching warning acknowledged.
Contradiction radar	Compare witness statements to other witnesses, docket facts, exhibits, and live testimony.
Safety workflow	Intimidation concern, last contact, escalation, protection referral marker, restricted access.

11.1 Witness risk scoring

Risk factor	Low	Medium	High
Availability	Confirmed for court	Unconfirmed	Unreachable or avoiding contact
Statement quality	Signed and clear	Needs clarification	Unsigned, vague, or materially incomplete
Consistency	Aligned with matter data	Minor differences	Material contradictions
Safety	No concern	Possible pressure	Threatened, intimidated, or vulnerable
Court performance	Prepared and confident	Anxious or unclear	Likely hostile, traumatised, or unreliable under pressure

12. Evidence and Exhibit Ledger

The evidence ledger is not a document folder. It is a structured proof-control system. Every evidence item must show source, status, authenticity, admissibility risk, chain of custody, linked witness, linked charge, and court status.

Evidence field	Purpose
Evidence ID	Unique exhibit or internal reference such as EXH-001.
Evidence type	Statement, photo, CCTV, WhatsApp export, bank record, forensic report, medical report, physical item, expert report.
Source	Person, institution, device, police station, expert, investigator, or system source.
Date received	Controls chronology and disclosure/audit history.
Chain-of-custody record	Tracks handovers, storage, sealing, digital hash, and authenticity state.
Linked charge	Shows what the evidence helps prove.
Linked witness	Shows who introduces or explains the evidence.
Admissibility risk	Flags search/seizure, authenticity, hearsay, chain, privilege, or constitutional risk.
Court status	Not introduced, marked for identification, admitted, disputed, excluded, withdrawn.

12.1 Chain-of-custody ledger

Step	Captured data
Creation/source	Who created or produced the evidence, when, and from what source.
Collection	Who collected it, date/time, location, method, authority.

Storage	Where stored, access restrictions, seal number, file hash for digital evidence.
Handover	From whom, to whom, date/time, reason, condition, supporting document.
Court introduction	Which witness introduces it, exhibit number, court ruling, objections.
Post-court status	Returned, retained, copied, sealed, appealed, archived.

13. Live Courtroom Capture and Testimony Intelligence

This is the flagship differentiator. The feature allows authorised users to capture courtroom sessions, create timestamped testimony snippets, compare live testimony with current matter data, and receive private prosecutor next-step suggestions. It must be permission-gated and human-controlled from day one.

Non-negotiable recording rule

Recording must be disabled by default. Legal Matters may only activate recording after the Court Recording Permission Gate is completed. Internal consultations, witness preparation sessions, virtual hearings, and courtroom sessions must each have their own recording basis and consent/permission logic.

13.1 Court Recording Permission Gate

Gate field	Required behaviour
Court permission status	Not requested, requested, granted, refused, or not required for internal session.
Permission basis	Court order, presiding officer permission, virtual hearing directive, internal consultation, or other lawful basis.
Recording scope	Full session, selected witness, argument only, ruling only, consultation only.
Sensitivity level	Normal, confidential, restricted, sealed.
AI processing allowed	Transcription only, AI analysis allowed, AI disabled.
Warning acknowledgement	User confirms legal responsibility and understands the transcript is unofficial unless certified.
Off-record/pause mode	User can pause recording and mark excluded sections.

13.2 Live courtroom mode

Courtroom Live Capture: State / Private Prosecution Matter

- Left panel: Live notes or transcript with timestamps
- Centre panel: Snippet builder and linked witness/charge/evidence selectors
- Right panel: Prosecutor Assist Panel: contradictions, missing elements, follow-up suggestions
- Bottom panel: Mark snippet | Link exhibit | Create task | Pause/off-record | End session

Live event	System response
Witness gives a new time	Compare with prior statement and docket chronology; suggest clarification.
Witness mentions new person	Create potential new person/entity note and investigator follow-up.
Witness identifies accused	Prompt prosecutor to clarify lighting, distance, duration, prior familiarity, and line of sight where relevant.
Witness mentions exhibit	Suggest linking testimony to exhibit and checking whether exhibit has been

	introduced.
Defence puts new version	Create defence version entry and rebuttal task.
Court postpones matter	Capture reason, responsible party, next action, and next court date.
Interpreter or equipment issue	Create court logistics risk and court-day readiness task.

13.3 Testimony snippet model

Snippet type	Trigger	Example prosecutor use
Identity	Witness identifies accused or connects accused to scene.	Clarify line of sight and reliability.
Timeline	Witness states date, time, sequence, duration.	Compare with chronology and other statements.
Location	Witness describes scene or movement.	Link to map, photos, CCTV, or jurisdiction.
Intent	Witness describes words, threats, planning, conduct.	Link to charge element requiring intention.
Possession	Witness places object, weapon, document, phone, money with accused.	Link to exhibit and chain-of-custody.
Contradiction	Live testimony differs from prior statement or other evidence.	Suggest fair clarification question.
Admission	Accused or witness states a material admission.	Mark for review and evidentiary treatment.
Forensic link	Witness mentions injuries, reports, DNA, blood, ballistics, cyber or accounting trail.	Link to expert report and missing expert task.
Procedural issue	Objection, ruling, postponement, interpreter issue, off-record moment.	Preserve for record and appeal/review risk log.

13.4 Autofill statement and testimony note rules

Legal Matters may autofill structured testimony notes and supplemental draft statements from live sessions, but these must not be treated as final witness statements. The correct output labels are: AI-generated draft testimony note, live testimony extract, court-session note, supplemental statement draft, or cross-examination issue note.

Allowed	Not allowed
Draft a source-linked testimony note for prosecutor review.	Generate a final witness statement without human verification.
Flag inconsistencies between prior statement and live testimony.	Declare that a witness is lying.
Suggest clarifying questions based on missing facts.	Coach a witness or tell them what to say.
Link live testimony to charge elements and exhibits.	Declare guilt or predict conviction.
Show confidence and source timestamps.	Hide uncertainty or unsupported assumptions.

14. Docket Intelligence AI

Docket Intelligence AI converts uploaded statements, documents, exhibits, reports, court notes, and evidence lists into structured prosecution intelligence. It must be source-cited, matter-limited, and reviewable.

AI action	Output
Summarise docket	Facts, parties, charges, evidence, witnesses, gaps, risks, next actions.
Build incident chronology	Timeline of events from statements, documents, reports, and court events.

Extract witness list	Witness names, roles, statement status, attendance need, risk indicators.
Extract accused profile	Names, aliases, identifiers, role allegations, contact details, bail status.
Generate evidence map	Evidence item, source, linked witness, linked charge, proof area, admissibility risk.
Identify missing evidence	Reports, affidavits, videos, metadata, bank records, medical records, chain-of-custody gaps.
Compare witness versions	Contradictions, timeline conflicts, new facts, missing corroboration.
Draft prosecutor memo	Case theory, key evidence, risks, missing items, suggested court strategy.

15. Prosecution Readiness Engine

The readiness engine should produce a matter-level score, per-charge score, witness readiness score, evidence readiness score, and next-court-date readiness state. It must be transparent, not a black-box score.

Readiness category	Weight	Sample checks
Charge elements supported	25%	Each charge element has linked evidence and witness support.
Witness readiness	20%	Key witnesses confirmed, statements signed, risks logged, interpreter needs addressed.
Evidence readiness	20%	Exhibits indexed, chain of custody captured, digital authenticity tracked.
Procedural readiness	15%	Disclosure, subpoenas, expert notices, court logistics, bail conditions tracked.
Court-date readiness	10%	Next appearance has brief, witnesses, exhibits, tasks, logistics.
Risk closure	10%	High-risk contradictions, missing evidence, intimidation alerts, media risks addressed.

Score	Meaning	System action
90-100	Trial-ready	Show green status and generate court-day brief.
75-89	Mostly ready	Show amber items and assign minor closure tasks.
50-74	Not ready	Escalate material gaps and require prosecutor review.
Below 50	High risk	Block ready status and generate risk remediation plan.

16. Court Preparation Workspace

Every court date should have a structured workspace. The product should generate a court-day brief automatically, including what is happening, who must attend, what evidence is needed, what risks exist, and what must be done after court.

Court pack item	Content
Appearance brief	Court, date, case number, presiding officer, appearance type,

	objective.
Witness list	Witnesses required, confirmed, interpreter needs, preparation status, risk.
Exhibit list	Exhibits to introduce, court status, linked witnesses, logistics.
Charge proof focus	Elements that must be established or clarified during the appearance.
Defence issues	Known defence versions, expected attacks, admissions sought.
Bail/safety issues	Bail conditions, intimidation concerns, safety actions.
Logistics	Courtroom technology, video playback, translator, remote witness, document copies.
Post-court actions	Outcome capture, next date, delay reason, tasks, evidence requests.

17. Bail, Witness Safety, and Victim Communication

Bail, witness safety, and complainant communication can change the entire course of a criminal matter. Legal Matters should include these controls as part of the prosecution OS, not as afterthoughts.

Module	Core controls
Bail Risk Workspace	Custody status, bail hearing dates, conditions, breaches, intimidation risk, public safety concerns, next bail review.
Witness Safety Tracker	Threat reports, last contact, safety level, escalation status, protection referral marker, restricted contact notes.
Victim/Complainant Communication	Plain-language updates, court date reminders, document requests, approved communications, trauma-aware templates.
Protection Escalation	Internal escalation route, responsible user, date escalated, status, outcome, audit trail.

18. Defence Version Tracker

The defence version tracker records new versions, allegations, alibis, identity challenges, procedural attacks, and evidentiary objections. It helps the prosecution respond with evidence, not emotion.

Defence issue	Data captured	System action
Alibi	Where accused claims to have been, time, supporting witness/document.	Compare with chronology, phone data, CCTV, witness statements.
Mistaken identity	Identification challenge basis.	Prompt line-of-sight, lighting, distance, prior familiarity questions.
Accident	Alternative explanation.	Map intent evidence and conduct before/after.
Consent	Where relevant, version and supporting evidence.	Track complainant evidence and procedural safeguards.
Police fabrication	Claim against investigation.	Review chain of custody, officer notes, body/audio/video if available.
Unlawful search/seizure	Basis of procedural attack.	Gather authority, warrant, consent, statutory basis, handover records.

19. Media, Public Risk, and Integrity Protocol

High-profile cases unfold in court and outside court. The product should help teams preserve integrity, manage leaks, avoid public commentary on merits, and protect witnesses from social-media contamination or intimidation.

Risk	Control
Media leaks	Access logs, restricted matter classification, leak incident register, evidence-view audit.
Public pressure	Evidence-only case theory, approval workflows, role clarity, no AI sensational language.
Political interference allegations	Decision trail, source-linked charge decisions, risk committee notes.
Social media misinformation	Issue log, witness contamination note, communication protocol.
Unauthorised spokesperson	Single spokesperson field, approved public lines, no-merits-comment checklist.

20. Role-Based Dashboards and UX

The prosecution vertical should have role-specific dashboards. A prosecutor needs proof and court readiness. A witness coordinator needs attendance and safety. An investigator needs missing evidence. An evidence analyst needs exhibits and chain of custody. A practice manager needs risk, workload, and deadlines.

Role	Dashboard focus
Lead prosecutor / attorney	Next court date, charge readiness, witness risks, missing evidence, live suggestions, defence issues.
Evidence analyst	Exhibit index, chain-of-custody gaps, digital hashes, evidence admissibility risk, linked charges.
Witness coordinator	Attendance confirmation, subpoenas, interpreter needs, safety risk, preparation status.
Investigator	Missing evidence tasks, new leads, witness follow-ups, forensic requests, defence rebuttal tasks.
Practice manager	Overdue tasks, delayed matters, court-date readiness, workload, high-risk matters.
External counsel	Selected brief, exhibits, chronology, witness list, charge matrix, court-day pack.

20.1 UX principles

- Courtroom Mode must be calm, fast, and low-distraction.
- Live suggestions must be private to authorised legal users only.
- Every AI alert must show source, confidence, and review status.
- Mobile should support quick court notes, witness confirmation, and evidence viewing.
- Desktop should support docket review, document comparison, charge mapping, and transcript review.
- Sensitive witness mode must visibly restrict access and AI processing.

21. AI Governance, Safety, and Output Standards

Criminal prosecution AI must be more conservative than ordinary legal workflow AI. It operates near liberty, reputation, witness safety, public trust, and fair-trial rights.

Required AI output field	Description
Output title	Matter summary, witness contradiction note, court-day brief, charge readiness report, follow-up suggestion.
Generated content	The AI text or structured output.
Sources used	Documents, statement versions, evidence IDs, transcript timestamps, matter fields, court notes.
Confidence level	High, medium, low based on source completeness and transcription confidence.
Missing information	What must still be verified, obtained, or clarified.
Suggested next action	Task, question, evidence request, witness follow-up, court-logistics action.
Human review status	Draft, reviewed, approved, rejected, superseded.
Audit entry	Timestamp, user, matter, action, source set, model/action policy.

AI may say	AI must not say
Potential inconsistency detected between live testimony and prior statement.	The witness is lying.
Current evidence appears to support this charge element, subject to prosecutor review.	The accused is guilty.
This issue requires clarification before the witness is released.	Ask this exact question to force a desired answer.
The transcript confidence for this sentence is low.	This is the official court record.
Evidence source is missing or unverified.	This evidence is definitely admissible.

22. Compliance, Privacy, Audit, and Security

The prosecution vertical must be designed for highly sensitive data: accused personal data, victim data, witness safety data, minors, sexual offences, sealed proceedings, biometric voice data, digital evidence, and confidential court materials.

Area	Controls
Tenant isolation	Every table includes firm_id. Server-side permission checks. No cross-firm access.
Matter restrictions	Restricted matters, sealed matters, sensitive witness mode, external counsel access windows.
Recording controls	Permission gate, start/stop audit, off-record pause, retention policy, restricted download.
Transcript controls	Unofficial label, correction history, review status, source timestamps, low-confidence marking.
AI controls	Policy by matter, excluded documents, source logging, review status, no final actions without approval.
Evidence controls	File hash, chain-of-custody ledger, tamper-evident audit trail, document versioning.
POPIA controls	Purpose fields, minimisation, retention, access logs, privacy notices, deletion/archival rules where lawful.
Audit logs	Append-only event history for critical actions and evidence/transcript changes.

22.1 Audit event catalogue

Event category	Examples
Criminal matter	Created, charge added, charge changed, accused linked, case status changed.
Witness	Statement uploaded, risk changed, prep logged, attendance confirmed, safety escalated.
Evidence	Uploaded, viewed, downloaded, hash created, chain handover added, exhibit status changed.
Court session	Session created, permission gate completed, recording started, paused, stopped, completed.
Transcript	Segment generated, corrected, approved, rejected, exported.
Snippet	Created, linked to charge, linked to evidence, approved, rejected.
AI	Docket summary generated, contradiction flag created, suggestion accepted/dismissed, source set used.
Access	Role changed, restricted matter opened, external counsel invited, failed access attempt.

23. Data Model and Schema Additions

The criminal prosecution vertical extends the base Legal Matters data model. Every tenant-owned table must include `firm_id`. Every matter-owned table must include `matter_id`. Important criminal tables must be auditable and version-friendly.

Entity group	Tables
Criminal matter	<code>criminal_cases</code> , <code>criminal_charges</code> , <code>charge_elements</code> , <code>charge_element_evidence_links</code>
Parties	<code>accused_persons</code> , <code>complainants</code> , <code>criminal_case_parties</code> , <code>investigators</code>
Witnesses	<code>witnesses</code> , <code>witness_statements</code> , <code>witness_risk_assessments</code> , <code>witness_prep_logs</code>
Evidence	<code>evidence_items</code> , <code>evidence_chain_events</code> , <code>exhibit_status_history</code> , <code>digital_evidence_hashes</code>
Court	<code>court_sessions</code> , <code>court_appearances</code> , <code>court_outcomes</code> , <code>delay_events</code>
Live capture	<code>court_recordings</code> , <code>testimony_segments</code> , <code>testimony_snippets</code> , <code>live_prosecutor_suggestions</code>
Readiness	<code>prosecution_readiness_scores</code> , <code>charge_readiness_scores</code> , <code>court_day_readiness_checks</code>
Risk	<code>defence_versions</code> , <code>media_risk_events</code> , <code>appeal_review_risks</code> , <code>safety_escalations</code>

23.1 Starter SQL schema extract

```
create table court_sessions (
  id uuid primary key default gen_random_uuid(),
  firm_id uuid not null,
  matter_id uuid not null,
  court_name text,
  court_type text,
  session_type text check (session_type in
('bail','remand','trial','plea','sentencing','argument','judgment','consultation','other')),
  session_date timestamptz not null,
  presiding_officer text,
  prosecutor_user_id uuid,
```

```

    recording_permission_status text check (recording_permission_status in
('not_requested','requested','granted','refused','not_required_internal_session')) default
'not_requested',
    recording_permission_basis text,
    ai_processing_allowed boolean default false,
    sensitivity_level text check (sensitivity_level in ('normal','confidential','restricted','sealed'))
default 'confidential',
    status text check (status in ('scheduled','live','paused','completed','cancelled')) default
'scheduled',
    created_by uuid,
    created_at timestamptz default now(),
    updated_at timestamptz default now()
);

create table testimony_snippets (
    id uuid primary key default gen_random_uuid(),
    firm_id uuid not null,
    matter_id uuid not null,
    court_session_id uuid not null references court_sessions(id),
    testimony_segment_id uuid,
    witness_id uuid,
    linked_charge_id uuid,
    linked_evidence_id uuid,
    snippet_type text,
    snippet_summary text,
    transcript_excerpt text,
    ai_reasoning jsonb,
    confidence text check (confidence in ('low','medium','high')),
    prosecutor_note text,
    review_status text check (review_status in ('draft','reviewed','approved','rejected')) default 'draft',
    created_by uuid,
    created_at timestamptz default now()
);
```

24. Technical Architecture and Integration Plan

Layer	Recommended choice	Reason
Frontend	Next.js App Router, React, Tailwind, shadcn/ui	Fast role-based SaaS UI with courtroom and dashboard workflows.
Backend	Next.js API routes initially, optional FastAPI for AI/transcription	Simple MVP with scalable AI/audio path.
Database	Postgres with row-level tenancy design	Strong relational structure for charges, evidence, witnesses, audit logs.
Storage	Encrypted object storage with signed URLs	Secure recordings, transcripts, exhibits, and documents.
Vector/search	pgvector or managed vector index	Matter-limited retrieval for docket and transcript intelligence.
Audio	Browser/media capture interface first, transcription provider later	Manual-first MVP without blocking future live transcription.
AI	Provider-agnostic orchestration layer	Controls prompts, source sets, policies, and audit logging.
Observability	Structured logs, audit logs, metrics, error tracking	Production discipline and traceability.

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24.1 Route map

/matters/[matterId]/criminal
 /matters/[matterId]/criminal/charges
 /matters/[matterId]/criminal/witnesses
 /matters/[matterId]/criminal/evidence
 /matters/[matterId]/criminal/readiness
 /matters/[matterId]/court-sessions
 /matters/[matterId]/court-sessions/new
 /matters/[matterId]/court-sessions/[sessionId]
 /matters/[matterId]/court-sessions/[sessionId]/live
 /matters/[matterId]/court-sessions/[sessionId]/review
 /matters/[matterId]/defence-versions
 /matters/[matterId]/risk-register

25. MVP Scope and Build Roadmap

Phase	Goal	Included capability
CP-1 Foundation	Criminal matter foundation	Criminal case type, accused, complainant, charges, court dates, status, basic dashboard.
CP-2 Evidence and witness hub	Structured proof control	Witness profiles, statements, evidence ledger, exhibit index, chain-of-custody notes.
CP-3 Manual courtroom intelligence	Live court workflow without audio dependency	Court sessions, permission gate, live notes, manual snippets, linked charges/evidence/witnesses.
CP-4 Docket Intelligence AI	AI-powered review	Docket summaries, chronologies, missing evidence, contradiction flags, source-linked outputs.
CP-5 Readiness engine	Operational prosecution readiness	Matter score, charge score, witness readiness, evidence readiness, court-day brief.
CP-6 Audio and transcription	Permission-gated recording and transcript	Recording service, audio storage, transcript segments, review workflow.
CP-7 Live prosecutor assist	Real-time support	Live cross-reference, contradiction alerts, follow-up suggestions, transcript-linked snippets.

25.1 MVP must/should/could/won't

Priority	Features
Must	Criminal matter type, charges, witnesses, evidence ledger, court dates, court sessions, permission gate, manual live notes, snippets, audit logs.
Should	Charge proof matrix, witness readiness, evidence readiness, docket summary AI, missing evidence tracker, court-day brief.
Could	Basic audio recording, transcript import, contradiction detection, defence version tracker, delay attribution dashboard.
Won't initially	Certified official transcription, automated court filing, direct SAPS/NPA integrations, fully real-time transcription in every courtroom, predictive conviction scoring.

26. Antigravity 2 Build Prompts

Use these prompts in Antigravity 2 in small controlled increments. Each phase should produce migrations, seed data, UI, permissions, tests, and manual QA notes.

26.1 Planning prompt

/plan

You are the principal product architect and senior full-stack engineer for Legal Matters Criminal Prosecution OS.

Goal: Extend the existing Legal Matters platform with a South African criminal prosecution vertical.

Produce: route map, data model, component map, API map, permission model, audit model, AI policy model, seed data plan, test plan, risks, and build sequence.

Non-negotiables: firm_id tenant isolation, matter_id on all matter-owned records, court recording permission gate, source-cited AI, no guilt findings, no witness truthfulness findings, human approval, append-only audit logs.

26.2 Build prompt - CP-3 Manual Courtroom Intelligence

/build

Implement Courtroom Live Capture and Testimony Intelligence - manual-first MVP.

Scope:

1. Add court_sessions, testimony_snippets, live_prosecutor_suggestions tables.
2. Add UI routes for court sessions, new session, session detail, live mode, and review mode.
3. Build Court Recording Permission Gate with permission status, basis, sensitivity, AI allowed, warning acknowledgement.
4. Build Courtroom Mode with live notes, manual snippets, witness selector, charge selector, evidence selector, prosecutor suggestion panel placeholder, pause/off-record marker.
5. Ensure all records include firm_id and matter_id.
6. Add audit logs for session creation, permission gate completion, live mode opened, snippet creation, suggestion creation.

Acceptance: user cannot start recording/live capture until permission gate is complete; snippets link to witness/charge/evidence; all actions are audited; restricted matters enforce permissions.

27. Testing and Quality Assurance

Test type	What to test
Unit	Readiness score calculation, charge element status, permission helpers, AI output schema validation.
Integration	Criminal matter creation, witness creation, evidence upload, snippet creation, audit logging.
Security	Tenant isolation, restricted matter access, sensitive witness mode, direct URL access.
Recording gate	Recording/live capture cannot start without permission status and warning acknowledgement.
AI	Sources required, missing info flagged, no guilt findings, no witness lying claims, excluded documents not used.
Courtroom UX	Live notes, snippet creation, linked charge/evidence/witness selection, pause/off-record marker.
Evidence	Chain-of-custody records, digital hash display, exhibit status updates, audit trail.
Performance	Dashboard load, large evidence list, transcript segment review, court session timeline.

27.1 Gherkin examples

- Feature: Court Recording Permission Gate

Scenario: User attempts to start live courtroom capture without permission

 - Given a criminal matter exists
 - And a court session exists
 - And the recording permission gate is incomplete
 - When the user clicks Start Live Capture
 - Then the system must block the action
 - And show the permission gate requirements
 - And create an audit log entry for the blocked attempt
- Feature: AI Testimony Snippet

Scenario: Live testimony contradicts prior witness statement

 - Given a witness has a prior statement saying the incident occurred at 19:00
 - And a live testimony segment says the incident occurred at 21:30
 - When the cross-reference engine runs
 - Then the system should create a potential inconsistency suggestion
 - And cite both the transcript timestamp and prior statement source
 - And avoid saying the witness is lying

28. Pricing, Packaging, and Go-to-Market

This vertical is high-value because it supports sensitive, document-heavy, witness-heavy, court-driven matters. It should be packaged as an add-on module to Legal Matters Professional, Practice Pro, and Enterprise plans.

Package	Target	Included direction
Criminal Prosecution Starter	Small firms/private matters	Criminal matter workspace, charges, witnesses, evidence ledger, court dates.
Prosecution Pro	Document-heavy practices	Docket AI, charge matrix, witness readiness, evidence readiness, court-day briefs.
Courtroom Intelligence Add-on	Trial teams	Court sessions, live notes, snippets, permission-gated recording architecture, transcript review.
Enterprise Prosecution	Institutions and high-profile teams	Advanced permissions, audit exports, custom workflows, integration support, dedicated security review.
AI credits	Usage-based	Docket summaries, transcript processing, evidence comparison, contradiction detection, court-day pack generation.

28.1 First market wedge

Start with private prosecution, complainant-side prosecution support, and criminal litigation teams handling document-heavy or high-profile matters. Avoid depending on institutional public-sector procurement for the first MVP. The best early customers are teams that feel the pain immediately and can adopt a specialist tool quickly.

29. Appendices

29.1 MVP user stories

Role	User story	Acceptance
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Prosecutor	As a prosecutor, I want every charge linked to evidence and witnesses so I can see whether the case is trial-ready.	Charge matrix shows supported, partial, and missing elements.
Witness coordinator	As a witness coordinator, I want to track witness attendance, safety, statements, and preparation.	Witness dashboard shows status and risks before each court date.
Evidence analyst	As an evidence analyst, I want to track chain of custody and exhibit status.	Evidence ledger shows handover history and court status.
Court attorney	As a court attorney, I want to capture live notes and snippets during testimony.	Courtroom Mode allows notes, snippets, links, and tasks.
Practice manager	As a practice manager, I want to see delayed and high-risk matters.	Dashboard shows delay log, readiness scores, and overdue risk actions.

29.2 Source notes

- Legal Matters Product Blueprint v1.0 - internal source document for base platform principles: matter-first design, role permissions, source-cited AI, audit logs, workflow packs, readiness scoring, and MVP delivery gates.
- Constitution of the Republic of South Africa, 1996 - especially fair-trial and accused-person rights in section 35.
- Criminal Procedure Act 51 of 1977 - procedural reference for South African criminal proceedings.
- National Prosecuting Authority Code of Conduct and prosecutorial independence principles.
- Witness Protection Act 112 of 1998 and NPA Office for Witness Protection information.
- Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013 - especially personal information, special personal information, biometric/voice recognition implications, purpose limitation, retention, access, and security safeguards.
- Supreme Court of Appeal practice directions and Magistrates' Court media access guidance - recording requires court permission and must respect fair-trial and privacy interests.

29.3 Product implementation warning

Legal review required

Before production release, this blueprint must be reviewed by South African criminal law practitioners, data protection advisors, and court-process experts. Court recording, audio processing, witness data, and AI-assisted prosecution workflows are high-risk product areas that require explicit governance and strict operational controls.